13
VACCINE DEVELOPMENT

15 JULY 2020

INDIA | 3,31,387 ACTIVE CASES | 25,047 DEATHS

WORLD | 45,30,879 ACTIVE CASES | 6,56,269 DEATHS

Over the last several weeks, officials from the Department of Biotechnology and the Biotechnology Industry Research Assistance Council (BIRAC) had been working closely with manufacturers of about 15 Indian vaccine candidates routed through discussions via the VTF. Determined not to stall a single candidate due to the unavailability of funds, they pumped in hundreds of crores of rupees in several of these companies at various stages during clinical and pre-clinical trials. They also offered technical support like making available clinical trial sites across the country, managing three immunogenicity assay laboratories and three animal challenge facilities.

All the way back in April, when Oxford University had arrived at a successful vaccine candidate, they tied up with several manufacturing companies around the world for scaling up production; SII being one of them. SII is the world's largest vaccine manufacturer in terms of volumes and was an early player in raising thousands of crores in order to develop and scale up vaccine production. However, several countries, especially the wealthier nations began an ugly race for vaccine hoarding, preordering significantly more doses than needed with multiple suppliers. In an effort to stop 'vaccine nationalism', the WHO along with Gavi, a Geneva-based organization and Coalition for Epidemic Preparedness Innovations (CEPI) created a joint fund called COVAX. The fund would carry the mandate to secure two billion vaccine doses out of which 92 million would be for low- and middle-income countries and the other billion for wealthier nations